> the journey taken by one vial of vaccines. From a plant in Pune or Hyderabad, the vial is sent to a hub in any of the states, from where it is transported to the district hub. From there, it reaches a vaccination centre. This entails the deployment of thousands of trips taken by flights and trains. During this entire journey, the temperature has to be maintained in a particular range that is centrally monitored.[13]

To attest as to how much of a Himalayan a challenge this truly was, Mr Poonawalla confessed to me,

> When the government asked me to produce 250 million doses per month, I thought to myself, well… I can still pool resources, scale up production and achieve this number. But it is them who'd have to administer those shots. It would mean injecting 250 million times, the man-hours required from the healthcare workers and last-mile delivery pan-India would be enormous. To be honest, I was sceptical of them achieving this! But look at us now, I am pleasantly surprised.

Many world leaders congratulated India and the prime minister on crossing this crucial milestone. WHO Chief Tedros Ghebreyesus tweeted, 'Congratulations, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the scientists, health workers and people of India, on your efforts to protect the vulnerable populations from COVID-19 and achieve #VaccinEquity targets.'[14] Bill Gates, in an opinion piece, highlighted five key ingredients because of which India was able to achieve this target: first, strong political will of the prime minister due to which state and local leaders responded with urgency; second, India's past experience with mass immunization campaigns lending experience, knowledge and infrastructure; third, harnessing of Indian expertise in vaccine and drug discovery and manufacturing; fourth, using its IT prowess to monitor the national vaccination drive and fifth, *jan bhagidari* or public participation.[15]

Most importantly, what achieving this milestone did for the country was that it made the citizens feel assured versus insecure, boosting confidence to continue our fight against the virus.

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